the unreliable self
a reader

Dionne Brand
Renee Gladman

INDEX

bios 5

A Map to the Door of No Return by Dionne Brand 7—16

Salvage: Readings from the Wreck by Dionne Brand 17—24

Calamities by Renee Gladman 25—31

The company that never comes by Renee Gladman with Lucy Ives 32—35

My Lesbian Novel by Renee Gladman 36—37

BIOS

Dionne Brand is the author of numerous volumes of fiction, poetry, and nonfiction. Her latest poetry collection, Nomenclature: New and Collected Poems, won the Los Angeles Times Book Prize for Poetry. Her other collections have won the Griffin Poetry Prize, the Governor General's Literary Award, and the Trillium Book Award. Her works of nonfiction include Bread Out of Stone and A Map to the Door of No Return: Notes to Belonging. From 2009 to 2012 she served as Toronto's poet laureate, and in 2021 she was awarded a Windham-Campbell Prize for Fiction. She lives in Toronto and is the author of new nonfiction book Salvage: Readings from the Wreck.

Renee Gladman is a writer and artist preoccupied with crossings, thresholds, and geographies as they play out at the intersections of poetry, prose, drawing and architecture. She is the author of fourteen published works, including a cycle of novels about the city-state Ravicka and its inhabitants, the Ravickians—Event Factory (2010), The Ravickians (2011), Ana Patova Crosses a Bridge (2013) and Houses of Ravicka (2017)—as well as three collections of drawings: Prose Architectures (2017), One Long Black Sentence, a series of white ink drawings on black paper, indexed by Fred Moten (2020), and Plans for Sentences (2022). Recent essays and visual work have appeared in POETRY Magazine, The Paris Review, Gulf Coast, Granta, Harper's, BOMB magazine, e-flux and n+1. She has been awarded fellowships, artist grants, and residencies from the Radcliffe Institute for Advanced Study at Harvard, Foundation for Contemporary Arts, the Lannan Foundation, and KW Institute for Contemporary Art (Berlin), and is a 2021 Windham-Campbell Prize winner in fiction. She makes her home in New England with poet-ceremonialist Danielle Vogel.

A Map to the Door of No Return
by Dionne Brand

pages 44—53

"Pray for a life without plot, a day without narrative."

1

I happened on this line by Derek Walcott in his book *The Bounty*. I cannot know precisely what he means but I recognized something in it. Or perhaps something in it called me. It described perfectly my desire for relief from the persistent trope of colonialism. To be without this story of captivity, to dis-remember it, or to have this story forget me, would be heavenly. But of course in that line too is the indifference, the supplication of prayer. Yet I want to think that perhaps there is also regeneration in its meaning.

"We need to have a cognitive schema as well as practical mastery of way-finding . . ." To reclaim the Black body from that domesticated, captive, open space is the creative project always underway. There are many stories, fables, and secrets in the Diaspora about the way home to Africa. In Toni Morrison's novel *Song of Solomon*, Milkman Dead's great-grandfather flies off to Africa; a song remains in the folklore, "a song" which leads Milkman to his own flight of salvation in the arms of his friend Guitar.

O Solomon don't leave me here
Cotton balls to choke me
O Solomon don't leave me here?
Bukra's arms to yoke me
Solomon done fly, Solomon done gone
Solomon cut across the sky, Solomon gone home.

Stories of Africans flying home to Africa or walking home on the ocean floor abound in continental America and the archipelago. Africans born in Africa were said to know how to fly. If when they arrived in the Americas, one legend has it, they did not eat salt, they could fly back home. Salt would weigh them down or turn their blood.

There is a story of a woman, enslaved, called Gang Gang Sarah who walked up the hill at Moriah, Tobago, climbed the silk cotton tree, and flew all the way back to Africa.

When I was a child, old people told these stories with the greatest equanimity, perhaps only lowering their voices as if telling an important secret in case one needed, at another time, a way out.

In Julie Dash's film *Daughters of the Dust*, upon reaching the shores of the Americas the captured turn and walk back into the water, their chains weighing them down, their faith of return unflagging.

A relative of mine was said to have walked out into the water at Guaya. Flinging his ring back to shore, he instructed it, "Go tell them I'm drowning." I do not know if he was trying to find his way home.

One may not call these ways practical but they certainly suggest a mastery of way-finding. So much so that no known map is necessary, nor any known methods of conveyance. Except escaping the body.

The religious ritual across North and South America and the archipelago of being inhabited by the gods, goddesses, and spirits of Africa may be another method of way-finding. A

neighbour from my childhood once told me that she was a Shango mother and that she knew many people who could go back to Africa when they "caught the power." Another even further back in my memory, one called Neighbour Lorna, lived in a house whose yard she had turned into a shrine, when at night the scent of a certain white flower emanated. She was said to deal in spirits whose renown came straight from Africa. She could inveigle them to help the lonely, the heartbroken, the sick, or the wicked.

Getting to the Door of No Return then needs no physical apparatus except the mind; the body is the prison. It is the body which makes the sign for sanction and regulation. It precedes its appearances, forecasting . . . It is why Baby Suggs performs the spiritual ritual of reclaiming and cleansing the body in the clearing in Toni Morrison's *Beloved*.

> *"Here," she said, "in this place, we flesh; flesh that weeps, laughs; flesh that dances on bare feet in grass. Love it. Love it hard. Yonder they do not love your flesh. They despise it. They do not love your eyes; they'd just as soon pick 'em out. No more do they love the skin on your back. Yonder they flay it. And o my people they do not love your hands. Those they only use, tie, bind, chop off and leave empty. Love your hands! Love them."*

2

The North Star, the Big Dipper, a dark sky, a clear night, a rabbit's foot, a juju bag, maljo beads, holy water, water of compassion, success powder, single bible leaf. Signs of rescue. With these their only compasses Africans escaped slavery in the Americas, made their way to remote places, maroonages. These signs were not signs to the way home but signs to somewhere free of signs for the body. But of course by this time the Black body was so freighted with the excesses and needs of the New World culture that even somewhere free was not quite sufficient. The signs did not fall away.

3

(*Guardian Weekly*, March 30–April 5, 2000—Austria)

> *. . . In January this year, when police raided the home of black Africans in Traiskirchen. "One hundred and forty police stormed the home looking for drugs but nothing was found," he [a witness] said. "They then carried out painful anal searches, simply because there was some suspicion that there might be drugs there. All you need is a black face to be considered suspicious." . . . The focal point of Amnesty's allegations is the case of Marcus Omofuma, a Nigerian asylum seeker, 25, who died while being deported from Vienna to Sofia in May*

last year. He was bound and gagged "like a mummy stuck to the seat" by the three officers who accompanied him, and arrived unconscious in Sofia where doctors pronounced him dead. No charges were brought.

"The White Wall of Silence," Jack E. White
(*Time*, June 7, 1999)

Suppose that on one fateful night in August 1997, New York City cop Justin Volpe had contented himself with pummeling Abner Louima with his nightstick instead of ramming a broom handle into Louima's rectum and then waving it in front of his face. Suppose that after that vicious assault, Volpe had not pranced around the precinct house with the blood-and-feces-stained stick, inviting other cops to examine it. . . . There would be a good chance that we would never have heard of Louima and that Volpe would still be patrolling his beat in Brooklyn.

(*Time*, February 3, 2000)

Diallo, an unarmed African immigrant living in the Bronx, was shot 41 times by four white police officers. . . . A police detective testified that Diallo's body was so riddled with bullets that some actually fell out of him as he was taken away from the scene.

4

There are other bodies in the world which are brutalized. These examples are not a case for exclusivity. Women in Afghanistan are entombed alive in burquas. The Taliban has forced them out of the public space; one cannot help but think that these men wish all women dead. They seem to require more than subservience, as they've constructed a vanishing of hundreds of thousands of women. There are countless other examples of brutalized bodies, bodies which play a role as talisman and sign. Not sobered by the emaciated bodies of death camps of the Holocaust, Europe revived these spectres in Bosnia. An endless parade of starved and famined bodies of ghostlike children in Ethiopia, Sudan, and Eritrea find television cameras and rich countries unaffected and racially superior. So, no, these examples are not a case for exclusivity, only for a certain particularity. A particularity which has its resonances against those other brutalized bodies.

5

The thing is that I think Blacks in the Diaspora carry the Door of No Return in our senses. It is a passport which, after boarding the plane, we are unable to make disappear by tearing it up and throwing it into the toilet. We arrive with its coat of arms, its love knot, its streamers, its bugle, its emblem attesting to our impossible origins. This passport is

from the territory of the Door. The territory is vast, its nature shiftable. We are always in the middle of the journey.

I know many nationalists along this journey. Each square foot of the Americas has its nationalism. And probably the most powerful of these nationalisms can be experienced in the U.S. But Jamaica, Brazil, Antigua, even the volcanic Montserrat are no less virulent. There are flags and anthems, even a real love for each place — the ways and objects and events which collect into nations. But the Door of No Return opens all nationalisms to their imaginative void.

One stands on a street corner in Ocho Rios or in a marketplace in Montevideo or at a newspaper kiosk in Chicago or Sofia, one stands there and imagines another territory, another history, and in that moment the fake emblems fall away. The cigarette falls from the fingers, its light singing into the gutter, the newspaper rustles in a catch of alien wind, the passion fruit feels leaden in the hand at the market, and one simply cannot make sense of one's time or one's unassuageable desire; one feels a strange discomfort and one sighs and takes off again into a life, a life against oneself.

6

To live at the Door of No Return is to live self-consciously. To be always aware of your presence as a presence outside of yourself. And to have "others" constantly remark on your presence as outside of itself. If to think is to exist, then we exist doubly. An ordinary conversation is never an ordinary conversation. One cannot say the simplest thing without doubling or being doubled for the image that emerged from the doorway. At a party you remark enthusiastically that you have been away, someplace where the sun has deliciously deepened the shade of your skin, and you look up from your bronzed shoulder to bewilderment. The self which is unobservable is a mystery. The mystery also plays out in the "private" space of the family in the Diaspora, where light or dark shading is related as proximity to the Door of No Return and to its secret ineffable quality. This mystery evades all the simplest powers of discernment in the public space. Every space you occupy is public space, that is, space which is definable by everyone. That is, the image which emerges from the Door of No Return is public property belonging to a public exclusive of the Black bodies which signify it. One is aware of this ownership. One is constantly refuting it, or ignoring it, or troubling it, or parodying it, or tragically reaffirming it.

7

Blacks in the Diaspora obscure themselves as much as they are obscured. They observe and rectify incessantly. Hair, skin tone, talk, fashion. Fashions are not fashions at all but refashioning; language is not communication but reinvention. They

are never in place but on display. Curiously the dynamism of these circumlocutions are the wellspring of culture in the Americas and with the dubious help of mass marketing they are the creative legs of an even more dubious globalization. Let me break it down. What is called Black culture, including aesthetic tastes and sensibilities, is used daily as creative backdrop to multinational markets. But more interestingly, what is produced in Black homes, and neighbourhoods, the simplest exchanges in communities — expressions, gestures, understandings, dress — these are taken up in the generalizing, homogenizing culture. In the language, for example; certain colloquialisms created in a city block of New York or Oakland or Kingston, Jamaica or Ladbrooke Grove, London become communal sayings far beyond.

8

This self which is unobservable is a mystery. It is imprisoned in the observed. It is constantly struggling to wrest itself from the warp of its public ownerships. Its own language is plain yet secret. Rather, obscured.

pages 8—15

This pronoun "we" that we invoke is, at base, a "we" of constant, detailed and expanding consumption, refracting in geopolitical and historical ways. All of us are recruited into this "we," whether we *have* the means, or whether we *are* the means by which others extract and consume.

"We" and "us" are always in flux. The meanings disaggregate with self-consciousness. "We" is an aggregate already disaggregated. And even in that partiality there is disaggregation.

We were made still by the pandemic. We were made still, and we could observe the great movement, the articulation of who was "we" and who was "we."

In the global North we were forced to come to terms with the rest of world. Not as labour pool, waste dumping site, theatre of war, arena of resource extraction; not as Globalization—meaning the complete annexing of the world's resources and labour supply in the project of neo-liberal capitalism. Rather, a broad "we" in the global North briefly felt the way it is to live in

the global South—under siege, under lack, under restraint. The world folded like cloth or like paper into the uncomfortable recognition of the "we"—of its geological whole. We suddenly felt the earth as if our feet were on the same shaky surface. The earth compressed its air and time together—and briefly made all distinctions superfluous. We went from world to earth to planet, and we realized the planet is indifferent to us. It goes on in any incarnation—it will sweep us away, it has no stake in us, it has no compassion. The pandemic allowed us to see and think; or forced us to see and think; or forced others among us to refuse to see and refuse to think—and it occurred to some of us that this is what it must have felt like for decades somewhere else. This was not some accustomed tragedy happening elsewhere, but everywhere; and for a short while "we" were not someone else, but everyone. Or: we were all someone else; and those of us who were someone else wherever we were, anyway—well, we were everyone *and* someone else as we always had been. The world altered. The global North could not distribute its usual knowing looks of pity and blame, divorced from its complicity in the conditions that emanate from our/its way in the world. We stopped. For a short time, that is, or for as long as most memory lasts in the global North—until the stock markets corrected themselves; until commentators reclaimed the racist narratives of difference. For a short time, we, or many of us, were stilled—until the supply lines figured out their new and old trajectories.

But this world-stillness hovers anyway; it is pressing over everyone and someone, over the indifferent planet; this world-stillness overrides and catapults, despite our ongoing right-siding toward a killing, stratifying, death-dealing normal. It is a stillness we encounter between every moment of living now; a stillness that cannot be described by the markets and the supply lines and the dominant interpretation of the normal; a stillness from whose attentions we cannot be reclaimed fully or returned to that dominant interpretation. In this stillness, we surmise that we must attend to some urgency in the process of defining itself.

Early in this season of stillness, this season of observation, when commentators and reporters tried to collect us into the generalizable "we," to breathe confidence into the faltering project of "we" in order to keep our spirits up, they asked, "How should we get through this time?"; and "What should we read to get us through?" They asked, "Has any writer provided us with a key, to understand, to transform; to escape this time; to cope?"; "Does the literary canon contain any balm, any advice?" The implied question was, Did a certain set of Euro or Anglo-American texts provide a roadmap to the way through and the way out? This, of course, pointed directly to the aggregate "we," the one that coalesces into whiteness, or the genre of the human whose precondition is whiteness. And right on time, someone wrote in the *Guardian*: "What We Can Learn from Elizabeth Barrett Browning's Years in Lockdown." The essay went on to read: "After being diagnosed with a severe respiratory illness, the poet was forced to live in isolation. Her response offers great insights into how to cope. Lockdown taught her actively to embrace the freedom to travel when it came." (And isn't this just where "we" are now, and why the planet will continue to heave? And just who can travel in this time?) The commentator continued, "Yet the same material was also offering me a fascinating

insight into how to cope with what was going on in my own world. . . . Her grasp of self-invention through a kind of 'second life' reminded me of all the friendships we were suddenly reconfiguring on Zoom. I also realized how closely her practice prefigured today's digital communicators: not just the teenagers and geeks, bloggers and TikTok stars, but citizen journalists, activists and those policed by authoritarian regimes too."[12] (I wryly note here "second life," and its resonance with that eponymous online game in which one creates an avatar and interacts with others.) The writer is trying to make some connection, to draw a line from the past to the present, but that's just it: this connection is through whiteness—the white "we," metonym for every "we," innocently, casually summoned.

In fact, we *are* summoned through the bourgeois life of nineteenth-century England: we are lathered in slaveholding and the fortunes made in enslavement. This summons arrived in the global North, in the middle of the pandemic, whole and aspirational, and as exemplar—as juridical in its demand. Naturally, if the world was falling apart during the pandemic, then its constitutive elements were also under siege; and if one of those elements was whiteness, then its tropes, its narrative history, needed shoring up. Its narrative proprietorship needed affirming. Or more innocently, the narrative apparatus that undergirded and attended its dominance rallied in its defence.

Harriet Jacobs never came to mind for the *Guardian* commentator, I observed. Nor did the enslaved woman who is the narrator of Browning's 1848 poem "The Runaway Slave at Pilgrim's Point." Elizabeth Barrett Browning, whose family fortune was made through slavery in Jamaica, lived at the same time as Harriet Jacobs, who spent seven years hiding in a crawlspace three feet high by nine feet wide by seven feet long, escaping Dr. Norcom, the white man who claimed ownership over her. She would publish, in 1861, *Incidents in the Life of a Slave Girl: Written By Herself.*[13] In this slave narrative she would recount her years in slavery, her seven years in confinement, and then her years in the north working to get her children free. Perhaps *this* is the text we should read for knowledge for surviving. Perhaps we should look for lessons at what Jacobs described as her "loophole of retreat"[14] (taken up so brilliantly by the sculptor Simone Leigh); perhaps we should look to Jacobs for an understanding of how to survive the crushing enclosure, and the existential void, for how to imagine and make real something like freedom.

I immediately thought, too, of all the writers I had read through the long time of our enduring, through outlasting the racism that brackets our lives, and hovers over all endeavours, presaging all appearances and events. And I found myself perplexed by these references to a literary canon that had surely tried to excise, by enclosure and confinement, Black experience in the Atlantic world by continually reproducing only white bourgeoise experience as "meaning." But, more innocently, my immediate reaction was of astonishment—as one is always astonished in this long durée of slavery and colonialism. "Goodness," I thought. "Read any writer in the Black Tradition and you will see how to get through. Or writers from the geopolitical South who also must find a way through and around the glutinous 'we.'"

Read *Beloved*, by Toni Morrison, where Sethe and Paul D survive slavery and navigate, attentively, their lives in the still fulminating anti-Black rage of Reconstruction and its brutal end.

Read, in Tsitsi Dangarembga's *Nervous Conditions*, of Tambu, Nyasha, Babamukuru, Lucia and others whose lives are under pressure as one cosmology forcibly eclipses another. Read Sam Selvon's *The Lonely Londoners*, where thousands emigrated by boat to London from the Caribbean, understanding their changing position and navigating this with humour and seriousness and everything that must be brought to bear in order to survive empire in the heart of empire. Read Edwidge Danticat's *The Farming of Bones*, where Haitian people in the Dominican Republic, over the course of seven days in 1937, experienced a genocide under Trujillo. In that novel, Amabelle Désir survives with compassion, having lost her lover and those around her. Read John Keene's sweeping diasporic *Counternarratives*,[15] which moves from the seventeenth century into the present, from Juan Rodrigues in the story "Mannahatta" to the speakers in the unnamed post-colonial interrogation room in the story "The Lions." Read these works to understand how sustained, intense pressure shuts a life down, curtails its movement, makes all plans indefinite, shapes all days, yet does not frame its purpose. Read there about waiting. Read there about patience and cunning and imagination and laughter.

So many novels in Black Traditions are novels of endurance and survival through times of material and existential dread and confinement. So many recount surviving and enduring with compassion, with resolve, with knowledge, with humour and a determination to live otherwise. These texts (novels, stories) come out of, metabolise, and work in, the world of nihilistic extraction. Their imaginative field is the great catastrophe that undergirds what we call the Americas. Over a reading life I have sought out and read these works as a salve, as a balm, as a map, as a trace, as an analysis, as a hypothesis, about the coming of freedom from within what is circumscribing and possibly fatal. A world is always ending in these books. A world is about to begin in these books, or about to be forestalled; about to, but not guaranteed to, "be" in these books. And this is the sensorium they chart. The novels' outcomes are living—when dying, of course; but living as if living.

The wreck is the library itself, and the salvage is the life which exceeds the wreck. Exceeds this library. *Solitary Boat in Red and Blue* exceeds the fragile boats, and renders the full desires they carry and hold.

So, I ask myself, what is a life alert in this sensorium and animated by books, as mine has been? What is a life making its way through this *monopoly of interpretation* (as Fredric Jameson calls it) that colonial narratives represent? Well, it might be a life animated but also destroyed by books—that is, animated but also destroyed by stories that override life, that overlay experience, that deny experience or quantify experience or adjust experience. What is that life? A life animated by books is something that everyone may understand, but a life destroyed by books is the more complex, contradictory, mysterious proposition. The wreck is, of course, possibly a life.

I observe, and live through, the monopoly of interpretation that relegates the art of those who live through catastrophe to spectacle or pathology, and into a symbol of the always not "we." Not art. Not an assemblage of the materials of perception that

appraise and know life and what is lived. Not a set of insights and gestures of transformation. So the risk of going forward here is the risk of being read by some in this way. When I use the autobiographical, it is as artifice. It is not an invitation to witness transparency. Where it appears, it will have been pored over, turned over, analyzed, refashioned as art, and made theoretical through those processes. The only place the autobiographical appears in my art with a small vestige of itself may be in the fictions that I write. And even then, alloyed.

This book is another kind of forensics. A forensics of how a reader is made. And, unmade. A forensics of the literary substance of which I am made—since it is possible that I am now mostly literary substance—and that I must recover from; and if not recover from, then piece together.

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Calamities
by Renee Gladman

David Horvitz, untitled *(Everything That Can Happen in a Day)*, 2011.

I BEGAN THE DAY THINKING that in order to write a talk on "The Ongoing Story" I would need to incorporate it into these essays I'd been writing about my life. I began, "I began the day staring into the face of the question of narrative—was anybody still interested in it, and, if so, why?" It was a simple question to ask but had taken me eight days to write—you'd think it impossible to construct a sentence two words at a time, writing two words then taking the rest of the day off then on the next day writing two more words, maintaining the thread the whole time, until finally, on the eighth day, you had it, the sentence, but this sometimes happened when you were writing about narrative inside of narrative. Recently, I had found that to talk about something that was in essence everything was simply too exhausting, and that the only way around it was to talk about the question of the thing rather than the thing itself, since in the end, it would become both. "Narrative—" I went on with my talk, "Was anybody still interested?
I didn't want to open my eyes to it. I hadn't wanted to think about narrative at the same time that I was conscious of my body lying in the object world. It was a problem of space similar to what Martha and I were discussing yesterday: Was it possible to say that something was gathering outside of a thing with the intention of meeting something

else when this something else was the larger space in which that first thing existed? Could I talk about narrative as I was operating within it? I closed the quotes enclosing the text for my talk and took a train to New York. I wanted to surround myself with other people who were thinking about narrative and asking themselves whether they were for or against it. Someone was having an event that evening, and it seemed appropriate to the essay that I narrate the events of the event before they actually happened. But not for the essay inside which I was writing the panel talk, rather the outer essay in which I felt isolated and needed to travel three point five hours to be among people. When I opened the quotes again for the talk I was thinking, It wasn't just narrative we were talking about but narrative in relation to poetic time, which was not the time of the object world in which I was lying but was the time of the essay to which I was attempting to draw the object world. Once the object world arrived I hadn't figured out what I would do in it (though you see the complication I was unearthing since I was already in it, the object world). Alev Ersan had left by this time. I wanted to tell her that the problem of poetic time was not a fiction, as I'd been, for years, calling it. Fiction did not concern itself with problems of time. If there was a problem inside a fiction—a problem of any nature other than what's happening inside the plot—then the whole thing would swell and small holes would form across the surface and the swellings would become as large as mountains while the holes would fill with water and become river valleys and soon we would be so far from the surface of the water that we'd recognize the picture of the mountains and valleys as a part of a geological map and recognize ourselves standing in an object world much larger than the object world in which we'd been lying when we began this essay. I closed the quotes when I bottomed out. I would have to open my eyes if I wished to understand fully where I was and whom I was with, if anybody. The figures forming in the light directed toward my closed lids (by the sun or the lamp I'd failed to turn off before falling asleep the previous night or by the panel talk that I was living rather than writing) would not grow in definition as long as I carried on not-seeing in this way, I thought as I closed the quote on this narrative. I didn't want, in the middle of the whole thing, to become anti-narrative. After the event in New York, which was formulated around the celebration of the appearance of a long-awaited thing, I was disappointed to find people more anti-narrative than narrative. Someone took my number instead of giving me hers—this was anti-narrative. We spent hours at a restaurant called the Half-King and were given the wrong check, which, when corrected, turned out cheaper than the right check. This was anti-narrative. Those of us standing around the table, hoping there would be enough money to cover the bill, were thinking anti-narratively about the people who had evaded this torture by departing early, their contribution

left behind. When we found there was enough money, even extra, we thought anti-narratively about our previous anti-narrative attack on those others. I wanted to turn our living toward narrative so suggested we all take the subway home. This was not agreed on, but we did all walk off together. Somehow it was only the black people who'd been in attendance that remained in our group. We walked along 23rd Street and I called Alev Ersan and counted off the number of black people with me. I counted seven, narratively. This was astounding, but I didn't tell the other black people what I was thinking, only Alev Ersan. This was anti-narrative. But clearly I was happy, as this configuration of blackness did not occur for me in the lonely little white city that I'd fled, thus was narrative. But within that, an anti-narrative moment, when I had to remind myself that it wasn't the little city that was white but rather the neighborhood in which I'd chosen to live. Imagine my surprise when I found it was possible to be both narrative and anti-narrative at the same time, which was like being a little overwhelmed in a large crowd. I was again pointed to a problem of time, or rather, space in time (it was hard to figure). How would I escape this crowd, but just to get outside it? Would it be possible to leave my name with someone? I closed the inner essay to look at the outer. I wanted to find a word or sentence that would prove there was an even larger essay that was a further outside of this one. I closed the quotes of lying in the bed with my eyes closed, and opened my eyes, looking literally into the face of the question of narrative, which was the emptiness of my apartment and the long stretch of day that lay ahead. "It would be good to begin another essay," I thought on the tail end of this one.

I BEGAN THE DAY GIVING a lecture to a group of university students. I said, "—" and made a certain gesture with my hand. They asked, "How do you know," with some small showing of contempt. Well, I was trying to say, "It's okay to think," but maybe what they heard was "You don't think" or "You are not thinking." I made the "Let's start again" gesture with my eyebrows, and calm was restored. I started over from the top, "In any case, one can see the city—" I was interrupted before I could replace the errant word. These were conservative students. I mean, "The sentence!" I yelled over their clamor. And as they grew quiet, one of them muttered, "You don't think," but he hadn't planned on being heard. He said, "I think you don't think?" by way of correction. We were trying to get to the heart of the matter. I said, from the head of the class, "This is really good," and smiled grandly, with so much love falling from my cheeks I worried that Alex Peters, sitting in the front row, might explode with grief. Everyone else grew sad, too. Someone—I don't remember who—raised her hand. She said, "We answer the way we do because we don't like your questions." And she was also smiling. I couldn't tell if this was a joke or something crucial about my teaching. I went on with my lecture,

"When you turn in your mind, you reach somewhere, open something, make some gesture." I paused. My notes had quotes around them. I was almost done.

I BEGAN THE DAY WITH the sense that if I could write down all of the words I encountered in Karasu's Gece, made a list of them then sought out their definitions, the eventual accumulation would most probably represent the entirety of the vocabulary of the Turkish language. It was determined that, by the date of my departure—six months hence of copying down that first word—I would be able to enter the culture and portray myself as a fluent, integrated speaker. This was a great plan, but it had taken hours to surface. I wanted to start right away. To my surprise, the first word of the book happened to be the title itself. I wrote "gece" and then "night" in a parallel column. I wrote "yavaş yavaş" (the second and third words of the book, which of course were the same word, though used differently from the first to the second) then wrote "slow" and "'slow'" respectively. When I went to write down the fourth word I found that I was exhausted. It occurred to me that I should nap before continuing the list. I had not slept the previous night, and I was beginning to feel a creeping desire to snack. As everyone knows, it's hard to make a list without simultaneously shoving bread or cheese in one's mouth. I had to choose eat or sleep, which also meant choosing Turkish or no Turkish, at least for that day. It wasn't as if I'd actually made a choice, just that at some point in my deliberations the doorbell rang and pulled me out of the first dream I'd had in weeks, which could only mean I'd been asleep, which must have happened despite the debate I'd been pursuing. It was all quite elusive for several long moments. The bell rang again. I opened the door to my apartment and yelled, "Merhaba," down the stairwell, precisely mimicking Rosetta Stone. "Nasılsınız," I said as Alev had taught me. "Iyiyim," I answered, though no one had asked how I was. "Ne yapıyorsunuz," I asked because nobody was saying nothing and I wanted to know what was going on. I walked quietly down the stairs but threw my voice so he wouldn't know I was coming. "Ikindi vakti," I said, because it was "the time of the two." So much was going on, and I'd been progressing so slowly down the stairwell, that I'd forgotten all about what I'd left upstairs—Gece, the snacks, the reported nap. When finally I arrived, I yanked open the door and shouted with g-force, "Kaç tane," because that was the first thing I had thought of. It wasn't pertinent. It didn't matter how many there were. I walked back up the stairs sleepier than ever with a package of what I believed to be the new Levitsky.

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I BEGAN THE DAY THINKING that in order to write a talk on "The Ongoing Story" I would need to incorporate it into these essays I'd been writing about my life. I began, "I began the day staring into the face of the question of narrative—was anybody still interested in it, and, if so, why?" It was a simple question to ask but had taken me eight days to write—you'd think it impossible to construct a sentence two words at a time, writing two words then taking the rest of the day off then on the next day writing two more words, maintaining the thread the whole time, until finally, on the eighth day, you had it, the sentence, but this sometimes happened when you were writing about narrative inside of narrative. Recently, I had found that to talk about something that was in essence everything was simply too exhausting, and that the only way around it was to talk about the question of the thing rather than the thing itself, since in the end, it would become both. "Narrative—" I went on with my talk, "Was anybody still interested? I didn't want to open my eyes to it. I hadn't wanted to think about narrative at the same time that I was conscious of my body lying in the object world. It was a problem of space similar to what Martha and I were discussing yesterday: Was it possible to say that something was gathering outside of a thing with the intention of meeting something else when this something else was the larger space in which that first thing existed? Could I talk about narrative as I was operating within it? I closed the quotes enclosing the text for my talk and took a train to New York. I wanted to surround myself with other people who were thinking about narrative and asking themselves whether they were for or against it. Someone was having an event that evening, and it seemed appropriate to the essay that I narrate the events of the event before they actually happened. But not for the essay inside which I was writing the panel talk, rather the outer essay in which I

felt isolated and needed to travel three point five hours to be among people. When I opened the quotes again for the talk I was thinking, It wasn't just narrative we were talking about but narrative in relation to poetic time, which was not the time of the object world in which I was lying but was the time of the essay to which I was attempting to draw the object world. Once the object world arrived I hadn't figured out what I would do in it (though you see the complication I was unearthing since I was already in it, the object world). Alev Ersan had left by this time. I wanted to tell her that the problem of poetic time was not a fiction, as I'd been, for years, calling it. Fiction did not concern itself with problems of time. If there was a problem inside a fiction—a problem of any nature other than what's happening inside the plot—then the whole thing would swell and small holes would form across the surface and the swellings would become as large as mountains while the holes would fill with water and become river valleys and soon we would be so far from the surface of the water that we'd recognize the picture of the mountains and valleys as a part of a geological map and recognize ourselves standing in an object world much larger than the object world in which we'd been lying when we began this essay. I closed the quotes when I bottomed out. I would have to open my eyes if I wished to understand fully where I was and whom I was with, if anybody. The figures forming in the light directed toward my closed lids (by the sun or the lamp I'd failed to turn off before falling asleep the previous night or by the panel talk that I was living rather than writing) would not grow in definition as long as I carried on not-seeing in this way, I thought as I closed the quote on this narrative. I didn't want, in the middle of the whole thing, to become anti-narrative. After the event in New York, which was formulated around the celebration of the appearance of a long-awaited thing, I was disappointed to find people more anti-narrative than narrative. Someone took my number instead of giving me hers—this was anti-narrative. We spent hours at a restaurant called the Half-King and were given the wrong check, which, when corrected, turned out cheaper than the right check. This was anti-narrative. Those of us standing around the table, hoping there would be enough money to cover the bill, were thinking anti-narratively about the people who had evaded this torture by departing early, their contribution left behind. When we found there was enough money, even extra, we thought anti-narratively about our previous anti-narrative attack on those others. I wanted to turn our living toward narrative so suggested we all take the subway home. This was not agreed on, but we did all walk off together. Somehow it was only the black people who'd been in attendance that remained in our group. We walked along 23rd Street and I called Alev Ersan and counted off the number of black people with me. I counted seven, narratively. This was astounding, but I didn't tell the other black people what I was thinking, only Alev Ersan. This was anti-narrative. But clearly I was happy, as this configuration of blackness did not occur for me in the lonely little white city that I'd fled, thus was narrative. But within that, an anti-narrative moment, when I had to remind myself that it wasn't the little city that was white but rather the neighborhood in which I'd chosen to live. Imagine my surprise when I found it was possible to be both narrative and anti-narrative at the same time, which was like being a little overwhelmed in a large crowd. I was again pointed to a problem of time, or rather, space in time (it was hard to figure). How would I escape this crowd, but just to get outside it? Would it be possible to leave my name with someone? I closed the inner essay to look at the outer. I wanted to find a word or sentence that would prove there was an even larger essay that was a further outside of this one. I closed the quotes of lying in the bed with my eyes closed, and opened my eyes, looking literally into the face of the question of narrative, which was the emptiness of my apartment and the long stretch of day that lay ahead. "It would be good to begin another essay," I thought on the tail end of this one.

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Calamities was produced by Triple Canopy as part of its Immaterial Literature project area, supported in part by the Brown Foundation, Inc., of Houston, the New York City Department of Cultural Affairs in partnership with the City Council, and the New York State Council on the Arts. Photograph courtesy David Horvitz.

The Company That Never Comes
by Renee Gladman with Lucy Ives

In her suite of essays "Calamities," in Triple Canopy's fourteenth issue, Renee Gladman asked, "Narrative-is anybody still interested?" Gladman speaks with Triple Canopy editor Lucy Ives about essays, ditties, half words, partial masks, and being a sentence writer.

Lucy Ives: Have more "Calamities" transpired?
Renee Gladman: I'm on page 45 of Calamities, which means there are probably about thirty essays now.
LI: They're about a page each?
RG: Yes, usually a page or a page and a half. I'm starting with a question or premise, like cleaning the espresso maker, allowing that to relate to a heavy topic, but treating it in a haphazard way, allowing that to change into something else or letting it fall off, because there's really nothing you can say. I start from the idea of being in the day, then generate an idea from it, let it fall apart, and see what the shape is after that. And for some reason they end up having this ditty shape of a couple pages.
LI: Say a bit more about this "ditty shape"?
RG: I call them ditties because they feel less like they're trying to travel; there is just one point that gets made in a quick circle. It's funny to call them essays anyway, because they fail as essays. They don't sustain an argument, they don't go anywhere, they don't conclude anything, and the half-paragraph ones seem even more so, kind of absurd. I mean, the whole thing is to allow me to have fun with some of my stresses, like teaching, being an academic, trying to get tenure, living in a sad, lonely city. It's a way of getting out of a kind of rut, a question I couldn't get past, what should I be doing with my writing.
LI: What should you be doing with your writing?
RG: If I were a really good drawer I would give up writing and just make beautiful line drawings, or at least for a while that would suffice, but I don't draw well enough to abandon writing. Sometimes I go around and talk about the sentence and prose, and for a while I was really stuck on how thoughts exist in a preverbal way. I was thinking about how in our minds we have many things going on simultaneously, as images, half words, gestures, partial marks, and from that multiplicity we go into the single line of articulation, of expression. I kept trying to point back to that threshold moment, that translation or becoming. The linguistic selection process, what you decide to privilege, is fascinating to me, but it's hard to know what to say about it. It makes writing a very interesting space. Writing is not a map, but something that comes after mapping.
LI: Do you think about a reader in that sense?
RG: It's bewildering enough trying to grasp "the person" in space and time; imagine trying to think about the reader as you write. For me, writing is a kind of pursuit of company that never comes. That comes, but then leaves or gets taken away; a pursuit that, because I write fiction, is embedded in the narrative. It gets acted out in the events of a narrator and another character or group of characters. I guess it is possible to see something about the reader in here.
LI: In the Ravicka novels, the linguistic gesture is itself a character.
RG: It would be much easier to talk about this if we were talking about poetry. In Turkish, when you bring food out to people, the people who are receiving it say, "Health to your hands," and the person who brought the food says in return, "Health to you." An encounter could have a bigger sort of performance behind it, so you're not just saying, "Thank you," but, "May birds fly through your hair at night." I wanted to embed in narrative these other symbolic possibilities. Somehow we get the idea that we can't say what we want, maybe it will make us cry or be too big for our hearts to contain. So we say, "Hi," but what we really mean is, "Will you pick me up and carry me across the street?"
LI: Ravic speakers say things like, "But could my body handle the three minutes of deep knee bends that I would have to deliver as my apology?" That seems like an unusual relationship to have with one's language.
RG: My feeling about English is that the subject-verb-predicate order enforces a pattern. Having the body as an extra means of communication is one way of addressing that limitation, but the body still imposes another kind of order. You age and can't communicate because you can't spend three minutes in a backbend or whatever. I really wanted to place the sound of the language in an Eastern European space, that felt important, a heavy consonant presence, I'm really

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drawn to that. I also started speaking this language, before I called it Ravic, aloud with a friend, so I could only say what my voice would allow me to say. Because of English and because I studied Spanish there was a lot of vowel presence I had to get rid of. With a name like Luswage Amini, syllables get pronounced the way a black Southerner speaks. It's like Lu-SWAGGE, kind of slow, drawn-out. I wanted that to be there. It's still this black girl who's writing about this place that's far away and not necessarily in conversation with her culture. One of my "Calamity" essays is about how I think black people and Eastern Europeans should have a conversation about possible overlaps between their experience, and what if I were to call myself an African American Eastern European, or is it an Eastern European African American, because I think about that.

LI: How does that "Calamity" fall apart?

RG: It starts, "I began the day considering the possibility that the person I am before I set my eyes upon the page I'm about to read—in this case, page 79 of Herta Müller's The Appointment—is entirely different than the person I am once I commence reading. I know this because I am not Eastern European in my real life." That's the entry point. The distraction is, "I can't get anyone to understand how the black person is another kind of Eastern European, esp. the Eastern Europeans... How eventful it would be for the Eastern Europeans to begin calling themselves black, or even black-Asian. How undermining of all that is the case for me to begin writing in my bios, 'Renee Gladman is an Eastern European African American.'" Then it says I would do this only to understand myself better as a reader.

LI: There's the reader again.

RG: I think the reader is there more, in "Calamities." There's this feeling that there is a community or interested parties who are reading these essays, because they are also junior faculty or are also living in lonely cities or also have a crazy idea, like that black people could be Eastern Europeans.

LI: It feels a little bit like an advice column that doesn't have the format of an advice column.

RG: I don't know how you would regard an advice column called "Calamities."

LI: That makes it really good!

RG: Ultimately, it's this performance of self. And this is why I don't have to end them, because it's an accumulation. If I wrote 120 pages of these essays, I would hope that through the accumulation of attempts to understand myself in particular experiences, maybe I would be something. That would be the self, an accumulation. We have these tiny moments, and it feels necessary in terms of surviving the day to put them together and see where we are.

LI: Why prose?

RG: I came up through poetry, but I am a sentence writer. I don't know if it's so much creating narratives as narrative space. I'm interested in time and experience and the sound of telling a story as opposed to the story itself. I have a love and deep interest in fiction, especially fiction in translation, so I teach that. But often in my workshops now I'll bring in texts that are hybrid, cross-genre works. It's useful as a way to get students to take more notice of language. I have students read poetry and then enter it from a sentence space.

LI: So the poem also contains the sentence?

RG: You can't avoid narrative in any kind of language space. And poetry is interested in experience; time is there, and the day. There are places where it pushes toward documentation and begins to remind me of what you might do in prose. Maybe not fiction. But in prose, how you might build sentences around an abstraction or feeling rather than plot points. I think it can only benefit literature for fiction writers to employ various degrees of compression in their approach to narrative.

LI: At the risk of going backward, what's the difference between fiction and prose?

RG: Fiction is interested in a certain kind of unfolding or sequence of events. Time is more intact in fiction. Prose, I think, introduces the element of the awareness of yourself in language as you are unfolding things in time and allowing yourself to be distracted or interrupted, allowing yourself to question the difficulty of what you're doing and be stalled, not to move. I want more fiction to do this, because it changes the way we read and understand story. With fiction that repairs all doubt and interruption and experiment by being fluid, coherent; what we expect doesn't leave much room for me as a reader. But I think the more you talk about these categories, their distinctions, the quicker they break down. Ultimately, what I want is for there to be a blur over everything.

I: Did you think about the novel?

R: Yes . . . in a way I drew so that I could think about the novel, which I find more and more difficult to write. Drawing opens up space around me, both interior and exterior space; it kind of lifts me off the ground, turns everything into energy fields I call math.

I: Would you say this is a dream state?

R: No, June is in a dream state. I live in something emptier (when I am alone, when I'm working). It's crisp and bright but also remote and, as I said, empty. When I think of dreaming, I see it more as an occupation. Being full of atmospheres that have a different sense of time. June wakes, her body is ready for the day, but the dreams, or the "being in a dream," being dreamed isn't finished. I'm drawing so as to write but to stay silent.

I: Do I pretend like what you've just said makes sense and ask you about June or do I try to find out more about this idea of "drawing so as to write"?

R: Well, I've written about this a lot in the past few years. But I can briefly talk about the ways in which this practice has evolved. When I began drawing, I felt a direct correlation between the lines I was making and possible lines of prose I could be writing. Hence, my calling them "paragraph drawings" and, more publicly, "prose architectures." However, most of them didn't look like paragraphs: they had too much space inside them. But, for me, they held the time of writing, such that when I drew I felt that I was *inside* narrative, seeing narrative, seeing its very construction from within (as I describe exhaustively in *Calamities*). I would repeat in many different forums: this is language with its skin peeled back. But it wasn't just a project that finished with the publication of *Prose Architectures*; it was as if those marks I used to build that particular set of drawings became a new lexicon for me. I had always drawn buildings when I drew, but not until the first prose architecture drawing did I draw buildings in concordance with writing. Once I understood my lines and my scripts and my cities as forms of prose, I moved forward through them into subsequent drawings (on larger paper, incorporating gouache, watercolor, now acrylics), still preserving, developing this feeling, this awareness and engagement that I was still writing. Now when I'm drawing, it's less that I'm drawing the time of writing or investigating narrative per se as much as I'm going into the math of the space that frames and backgrounds writing. These are thinking spaces that take the form of charts, maps, energy readings. It's a very interior measurement. It's like being in the most inside of a thing or a question. Although I have never understood math, this is what I've thought math to be: a way of measuring the most inside of something.

I: But how does this process allow you to think about this novel specifically?

R: While I said to draw was to write, I should also say sitting in a kind of electrified stillness—how I see the posture of thought—is also writing. I often talk to Danielle about the big anxiety of my day as an artist: the need to make bridges from one part of the day to another, from one form of creating to the other, from sun to twilight, and within these major turns all the minute shifts that happen. Sitting in thought . . . I'm leaning into this buzz and that's where the novel exists. I'm asking all day: How do I put myself in the proper state to write out these dreams that have struck June, these weathers that move through her? When I'm drawing, I'm no longer still, but I am still leaning into the buzz. I'm trying to become porous.

I: And did it work? Are you now ready to go on with the novel?

R: Yeah, I think I have enough to move further now . . .

This reader was printed on the occasion of the *...have ...word* reading group organized by rile* between January 26th and April 24th 2025 in Brussels.

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